

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Jehoson Jiresh J. K. Abarna SriPreethi

For generations, the pursuit of grades or marks has ruled Indian academia. Teachers often lament that this socially constructed obsession with high scores impedes authentic contextual learning. Yet the contemporary learner is moving away from a test-oriented approach to ask: What will I get by doing this? They want to know how their exam-related efforts will bear immediate financial fruit. Hence, learning- and earning-oriented assessments become imperative. An assignment should no longer be a piece of paper that a teacher grades and forgets. It needs to become a real socio-economic asset that informs policy decisions and generates revenue.

New framework To evolve such assessment practices in the AI age, we should stop playing the role of a detective, trying to catch students using AI. Therefore, we propose the PRISM-X evaluation framework to assess AI-generated assessments effectively. PRISM-X stands for Prompting efficacy, Reflective capability, Integrating competence, Synthesising potential, Metacognitive ability, and Extended collaboration. When broken down, the components of PRISM-X are as follows: **Prompting efficiency:** Assess how students actually converse with the



Beyond the red pen

How assignments can be converted into a socio-economic asset

machine. Are they tossing out lazy questions? Or engineering razor-sharp prompts? Handing over every prompt and follow-up query, along with the final assignment, is strictly mandatory. **Reflective capability:** The machine generates an answer but does the student swallow it as it is? Or do they spot the cracks? The true test is the human critique of the AI-generated content, catching the bias and calling out misinformation. **Integrating competence:** AI-generated content may produce raw data but it is crucial to breathe meaning into it. How well

learners fuse sterile facts with original and contextualised thought matters. In context, a paper on climate studies requires more than just algorithmic Maths. It demands the grit of experience and insights from classroom debates and lived reality. **Synthesising potential:** This considers the learner's ability to use existing knowledge to develop new theories, frameworks, and public discourses. For instance, a standard Sociology essay could become an engaging podcast script that creates awareness and generates revenue. Therefore, what is evaluated is the ability to

package academic concepts into accessible formats that the real world actually values. **Metacognitive ability:** This aims to answer crucial questions about learning in itself, such as whether leaning on technology breeds laziness or stimulates deeper thinking. Hence, learners are expected to articulate their learning process to prove that AI served as a springboard for cognitive growth. Validation can be through an oral defence of their own assignments, demonstrating the learning process as a conceptual orchestrator rather than a passive consumer of AI-

generated content. **Extended collaboration:** Does the assignment live beyond the classroom walls? It assesses whether the project produces tangible socio-economic impact. For instance, a basic coding task should not just be graded and discarded but could be developed into software for a local charity initiative to track donations, thereby delivering real-world impact. **Ethics of money** While encouraging learners to make money using their assessments may seem like commercialising learning, it must be noted that commercialisation of

education has already been rationalised. But the greater responsibility lies with educators to channel student ideas about money by deliberating on fair earnings. When assignments begin to earn money, classrooms must discuss their worth: self-worth, social worth, and net worth in that order. In the words of Thiruvalluvar, the world offers no place to those without wealth and the inner world offers nothing to the unkind (Kural 247). We must equip learners to create wealth with kindness, a much-needed juxtaposition. When students are given assignments that matter in the real world, they are empowered as knowledge producers. So, educators must ask one fundamental question before assigning a task. If this assignment created real-life knowledge but scored fewer marks, would the student still feel proud to share it? When the answer is yes, higher education will have truly evolved to nurture conscious creators and thought leaders, not merely for future jobs but to shape the future with progressive thought and action. *Views expressed in this article are personal.*

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SCHOLARSHIPS

SBI Platinum Jubilee Asha Scholarship An initiative of SBI Foundation **Eligibility:** Indian nationals in school (Class 9 to 12), UG or PG courses with at least 75% or 7.9 CGPA (10% relaxation for SC/ST students) and an annual family income not exceeding ₹300,000 (school students) and ₹600,000 (other categories). **Rewards:** Variable depending on category. Renewal is not automatic. **Application:** Online **Deadline:** September 4 www.b4s.in/edge/SBISF20

HDFC Parivartan ECSS Programme An initiative by HDFC Bank. **Eligibility:** Indian nationals in school (Class 1 to 12) or pursuing a diploma, ITI, polytechnic, UG and PG

(general and professional) course with minimum 55% in the most recent qualifying exam. Annual family income must not exceed ₹250,000. **Rewards:** Up to ₹75,000 based on level. **Application:** Online **Deadline:** August 31 www.b4s.in/edge/HDFC63 **Mahindra All India Talent Scholarship** Offered by the K.C. Mahindra Education Trust. **Eligibility:** Indian nationals belonging to the low-income group who have passed Class 10 and 12 exams with more than 60% and are in the first year diploma course in a recognised polytechnic institute. **Rewards:** ₹10,000 a year for up to three years. **Application:** Online **Deadline:** August 31 www.b4s.in/edge/MATII

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Hackcessible India

The University of Sheffield, the U.K., invites entries for Hackcessible India, an online assistive technology innovation challenge for young engineering enthusiasts across India. Open to students in Classes 11 and 12 from schools across India,

the initiative offers students an opportunity to work collaboratively and develop practical assistive technology solutions that address the needs of people with disabilities. Deadline to register is September 6. The challenge will run from September 7 to December 12. For more information, visit https://shorturl.at/vR6n3

Trust your instincts

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help



OFF THE EDGE **Nandini Raman** I have passed Class 12 (PCMB) with a state rank of 10 and have taken NEET 2026 and KCET. I want to pursue B.Sc. Chemistry but people say I should not do so because I have such good marks. I am also considering BDS or a B.Sc. Paramedical course. How should I choose the correct college? Name withheld

The attitude that a B.Sc. means "wasting" good marks is outdated. High scorers choose B.Sc. degrees not because they lack options but because they want to pursue research and specialised fields. Choose a career that aligns with your strengths and interests, not other people's expectations. B.Sc. Chemistry can be an excellent foundation for Computational Chemistry, Molecular Modelling and even Quantum Machine Learning. An M.Sc./Ph.D. can open opportunities in global R&D labs, research and technology, and the pharma sector. Study Python, data structures and machine learning alongside your degree. Look for institutions where science is treated as a research discipline and ones that have four-year B.S./B.Sc. (Research) programmes such as IISc, IISERs and strong universities with active DST/CSIR-funded research. While choosing a college, examine its laboratories, equipment, computing facilities, faculty publications, computational chemistry projects and industry connections. Remember that moving into research from dentistry or allied health is relatively uncommon. Trust your instincts and invest in a discipline you find genuinely fascinating.

I am from Arunachal Pradesh and want to pursue BBA and CA. I have interested in business, finance and entrepreneurship from a young age. Would a BBA followed by CA be a suitable path? Rose

Dear Rose, While BBA and CA are valuable, this combination may pull you in two different directions. BBA is qualitative and theoretical, covering Human Resources, Marketing and Organisational Behaviour. CA is heavily technical, analytical and compliance-driven, covering Taxation, Auditing, Corporate Law and Advanced Accounting. You need to complete practical training under a practising CA after the first exams. This means working full time. Given your goals, I would recommend B.Com and CA. The B.Com syllabus aligns with CA Foundation and Intermediate, covering Financial Accounting, Mercantile Law and Economics. A college with relaxed attendance, or distance/correspondence study, can free up time to clear CA Inter and begin Articleship. Alternatively, consider BBA Finance with CFA if your interest in finance is more about start-up valuation, venture capital and investing. BBA Finance teaches you how companies operate and scale, while CFA teaches you how markets value them. CFA does not require a rigid daytime articleship, allowing you to enjoy college, network and develop business ideas. Look for colleges with active E-Cells or incubators. Since you are from Arunachal Pradesh, keep an eye on the Northeast Venture Fund and

Startup Arunachal for grants, subsidies and soft loans. **After PG English Literature, I have been placed as a technical writer. How can I prepare for this and use it to expand my career options? Treesa**

Dear Treesa, View this role as a masterclass in tech dynamics. Learn Document-as-Code and Markdown. Modern software companies rarely use MS Word; they write documentation in Markdown and manage it like code. Download VS Code, install a Markdown preview extension, and practise formatting. Learn Git basics: cloning a repository, creating a branch, and making a pull request on GitHub. API documentation is a valuable niche. Learn what an API is. Explore Swagger or Postman and understand how developers read technical endpoints. At work, volunteer for tasks and seek opportunities to work with Product Management, UX/Content, Product Design, Strategists and Researchers. Upskill in Data Literacy (SQL basics), Product Thinking, AI Prompting and LLMs such as Gemini. Learn to co-author with AI to accelerate editing, formatting and brainstorming. Enjoy this phase. Enjoy learning and exploring. **I completed graduation in English Language and Literature and PG in Rural Development but am not able to find a prestigious or high-paying job. Do I need other degrees or skills? Ananya**

Dear Ananya,

A PG in Rural Development channels freshers into grassroots NGO roles, field operations, or basic block-level jobs, which are highly impactful but often underpaid at the entry level. To pivot into a high-paying corporate or international track, you need to stack specific, in-demand technical skills. The high-paying jobs in social and rural development happen in corporate boardrooms, consulting firms, and international think-tanks. Your English background is a massive advantage in communication, writing, and synthesis, while your PG gives you domain knowledge. Look at Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) Management. Large corporations hire professionals to design, budget for, and manage these projects. International bodies hire Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) / Data Analyst specialists to track whether rural development schemes work. Learn Advanced Excel, data visualisation tools like Tableau or Power BI, and basic statistical analysis. You could also consider Public Policy and Development Consulting. Build a portfolio that proves you can execute corporate development tasks. Take certification courses on Coursera, Udemy or LinkedIn Learning. Analyse a government rural scheme and publish it on LinkedIn as a visual resume. Look for jobs on DevNetJobs India, NGOBox and the career pages of large foundations. Network actively, as many high-paying roles are filled before they are advertised. **Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.** The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

Pivush Roy

“The only constant in life is change,” stated Heraclitus, the ancient Greek philosopher. AI has accelerated the pace of change beyond any historical precedent. Its impact, arguably, is as profoundly life-altering as the discovery of fire. AI is not merely a tool; it is the primary driver of the ‘creator economy’, popularly known as the ‘Orange Economy’. As creative industries move from the cultural margins to the global economic mainstream, India stands at the threshold of a content and careers revolution. The sector has a projected value of \$50 billion by 2029. Is our education system prepared to empower the next generation of creators?

Rapid expansion The traditional boundaries of innovation are expanding beyond the classic STEM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Maths) model into a more diverse, inclusive and dynamic framework - Sports, Technology, Entrepreneurship, and Media. The media space is expanding rapidly from the traditional print, electronic and film to digital, OTT, Animation, Visual Effects, Gaming, Comics, and Extended Reality (AVGC-XR). India is at a critical inflection point in this expansion with the opportunity to transition from a back-office service provider to a global powerhouse of content creation, intellectual property (IP), and immersive technology. A young talent pool can drive this transition, provided the creative industries education shifts from a culture

Create, network, monetise

A four-pillar guide to re-imagining education for the creative industries

of ‘producing and selling’ to one of ‘creating and networking/monetising’. Creative industries include content creators, filmmakers, animators, VFX artists, artists, and multimedia professionals. Traditionally, students gained skills in one of these disciplines, which were then honed through short internships before competing for placements in the final year. This approach has to change. **Rejig the curriculum** Curriculum structures have to go beyond knowledge dissemination to encompass knowledge creation, curation, and monetisation within the existing four-semester (PG) or four-year (UG) programmes. For creative entrepreneurs to understand the full lifecycle of their craft and the dynamic nature of their industries, the passive ‘learning-to-do’ model has to be exchanged for an active ‘human-centric thinking-driven’ ecosystem, through the proposed four-pillar model: Foundation - Production - Immersion - Curation. **Foundation:** The cornerstone of this new model lies in building intellectual depth before immersion in vocational instruction. Before getting into the ‘what and how to do’, students should start with ‘how to think’ about the ‘why’ of what they intend to do. By

immersing students in human history, philosophy and the evolution of the arts and storytelling, the roots necessary for any creative pathway are inculcated. This ensures that creators are not just learning a trade but also developing the cognitive adaptability of lifelong learners and can outpace or evolve with any technical shift in their industry. **Production:** In the ‘Making Phase’, theory is transformed into high-stakes execution. Technical skill is applied not as an end in itself, but as a vehicle to create signature work with some tangible market value. Whether in filmmaking, VFX, or multimedia, technical proficiency should be aligned towards discovering and nurturing a student's unique creative voice. The portfolio ceases to be a grade and becomes a professional asset. **Immersion:** Real-world business literacy should be embedded into the curriculum with a focus on making and understanding the business. This equips creators to view their work through a lens of global trends and multicultural appeal. By mastering distribution models and self-marketing, students learn how intellectual property (IP) moves through a digital-first eco-

system, ensuring that they understand how to reach their audience from day one. **Curation:** The final phase focuses on understanding the professional ecosystem they are about to enter through networking and entrepreneurship. This can be achieved by engaging in curated industry events to build professional relationships, learning to curate their own industry interaction spaces, and training in practical, day-to-day people engagement to bridge the gap between ‘just qualified’ and ‘truly hireable’. This trains students in the art of people engagement and professional relationship building that enable a creator to build the networks and relationships that sustain a lifelong career. To thrive in the high-stakes Orange Economy, creative education must evolve into a ready and responsive ecosystem. Complementing academic capstone project outcomes (films, theses, prototypes) with active capstone experiences (such as film festivals, thematic events, industry networking showcases) will nudge students towards delivering tangible professional assets. Only then can a new generation of ‘educated’ creators move from being participants to drivers. *Views expressed are personal*

The writer is an author, filmmaker, professor, and Dean of the School of Film, Media and Creative Arts, RV University, Bengaluru.



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WIDE ANGLE
Albert P' Rayan

Me: Lalitha, you’ve been colouring all this time. Do you enjoy colouring?

Lalitha: Yes, I do.
Me: What’s your favourite colour?

Lalitha: Pink.
Me: Why do you like pink?

Lalitha: Don’t you know that all women like pink?

Me: I don’t know. Why do women like pink?

Lalitha: Let me ask ChatGPT.

Me: Why do you want to ask ChatGPT?

Lalitha: It gives answers to all our questions.

This was an informal conversation I had with two young British-Indian children – a seven-year-old boy and his four-year-old sister, Lalitha – during a train journey from Coimbatore to Chennai.

Throughout the seven-hour journey, the children

kept themselves busy colouring, drawing, and knitting, while also engaging in conversation with my family and I.

Although brief, the exchange offers an interesting glimpse into how young children are beginning to perceive and interact with AI. Lalitha’s response shows her natural curiosity and her perception of ChatGPT as a convenient source of information. Her desire to turn to AI is purposeful and curiosity-driven. At the same time, her belief that ChatGPT “gives answers to all our questions” raises an important concern.

Children need to understand that AI does not necessarily have all the answers and that its responses may not always be accurate. The real question is not whether children should use AI but how we can teach them to use it wisely without allowing it to replace their own curiosity, questioning and thinking.

Common concern

Recently, I spoke on the topic, Does AI make acade-

More than AutoCAD

The new tech stack every civil engineer must master



Roy Aniruddha

For several decades, AutoCAD has remained the foundational tool in Civil Engineering practice. It has shaped how design documentation is produced, reviewed, and executed across projects of varying scales. However, in the current trajectory of the Architecture, Engineering, and Construction (AEC) industry, AutoCAD is no longer sufficient as a standalone competency for modern civil engineers.

Today, projects require integrated digital environments that combine geometry, data, simulation, and lifecycle management. This shift necessitates a broader and more advanced technological skill set.

Importance of BIM

Traditional Computer-Aided Design (CAD) tools primarily focus on geometric representation. In contrast, contemporary workflows are centred on Building Information Modelling (BIM), where every component is embedded with structured data attributes. Within BIM environments, elements such as walls, slabs, beams, and systems are not merely graphical entities but data-rich objects containing specifications, material properties, cost parameters, and performance characteristics. This enables a model-based approach to design, analysis, and documentation. Accordingly, civil engineers are required to transition from drafting-centric methodologies to information modelling frameworks.

BIM is often misinterpreted as software proficiency. Actually it is fundamentally a process-oriented framework. Platforms such as Autodesk Revit and Graphisoft Archicad serve as implementation tools rather than conceptual definitions of BIM itself. Its core value lies in its capacity to integrate multidisciplinary inputs within a unified en-

vironment. Structural, architectural, and MEP systems are coordinated within a single federated model, enabling real-time consistency across design changes. This eliminates redundancy inherent in 2D workflows and significantly reduces documentation discrepancies across disciplines.

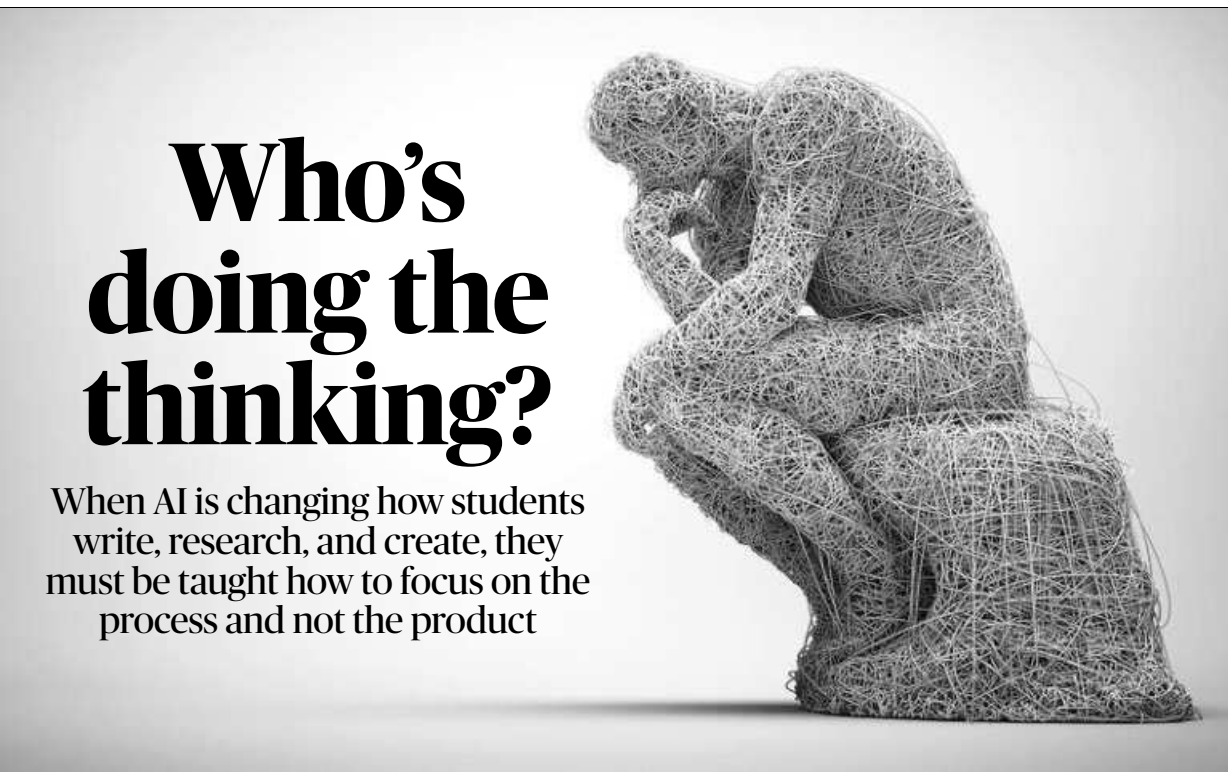
One of the most critical advances enabled by BIM workflows is automated clash detection. Coordination platforms such as Autodesk Navisworks and Solibri facilitate the identification of spatial- and system-level conflicts before construction. Clashes between structural and service elements, if undetected, often lead to significant cost escalations and construction delays.

The ability to resolve such conflicts at the design stage represents a substantial improvement in project risk management and execution efficiency. Thus, coordination is no longer a post-design review activity but an integral component of the design process itself.

The extension of BIM into 4D (time) and 5D (cost) dimensions represents a significant advancement in project planning methodologies. 4D BIM integrates construction sequencing with the digital model, enabling simulation of project execution over time. This provides stakeholders with a visual representation of construction phasing and progress. 5D BIM further integrates cost data with model components, allowing real-time cost estimation and financial forecasting linked directly to design modifications. Together, these dimensions establish a more dynamic and data-driven approach to project control.

Reality capture

The integration of reality capture technologies, including LIDAR scanning, photogrammetry, and UAV-based surveys, has significantly improved the accuracy of existing condition modelling. These



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Who’s doing the thinking?

When AI is changing how students write, research, and create, they must be taught how to focus on the process and not the product

mia think, blink or sink?, at a conference organised by Rajalakshmi Engineering College, Chennai. I began with “If you’re in academia and say you don’t use Artificial Intelligence (AI) tools, you’re either outdated or lying.”

Everyone in the audience acknowledged using AI for various purposes, including generating

ideas, gathering information, and editing. They also shared a growing concern: AI use has become common among students and very few now write assignments without AI assistance. As a result, it is becoming increasingly difficult to get students to write and think independently.

Discussions about AI in

education bring forth positive and negative views. Critics argue that AI kills creativity and intellectual curiosity, destroys critical thinking, threatens academic integrity, and prevents genuine learning. Some even believe that the best way to preserve learning is to ban AI.

Are these statements facts or myths? I would ar-

gue that they are largely myths or sweeping assumptions. AI itself does not determine whether students think or stop thinking. Its impact depends on how it is used. It can serve as a creative ally that stimulates ideas and deepens learning or become a crutch that encourages intellectual dependence.

enable the generation of high-fidelity point clouds that can be converted into BIM-ready environments.

This is particularly critical in retrofit, infrastructure rehabilitation, and large-scale transportation projects where as-built documentation is often incomplete or outdated. The convergence of physical and digital datasets enhances design reliability and reduces uncertainty during construction.

The increasing adoption of computational tools such as Dynamo, Grasshopper, and Python scripting within design workflows reflects a broader shift toward algorithm-driven engineering. These tools enable parametric modelling, optimisation of design variables, and automation of repetitive tasks.

As a result, engineers can evaluate multiple design iterations efficiently while improving precision and reducing manual workload. This evolution signifies a transition from static design generation to rule-based and performance-driven modelling.

Cloud-based platforms

Modern construction projects are inherently collaborative and distributed. Cloud-based platforms such as Autodesk Construction Cloud and BIM 360 facilitate centralised data management, version control, and issue tracking across geographically dispersed teams, ensuring that all stakeholders operate with a single source and minimising discrepancies arising from fragmented communication channels and outdated documentation. Such systems are now essential for maintaining consistency in complex, multi-stakeholder projects.

The most advanced application of integrated digital workflows is the concept of digital twins, virtual representations of physical infrastructure assets that are continuously updated with operational data. Digital twins extend the utility of BIM beyond construction into operations and maintenance. Infrastructure such as airports, metro systems, and smart cities increasingly rely on these models for performance monitoring, predictive maintenance, and asset optimisation.

Therefore, while AutoCAD remains a foundational tool, it no longer defines professional competency, as the role of the civil engineer is evolving from a document producer to a systems-oriented digital engineer.

The writer is co-Founder and Chairman, TechnoStruct Academy

Aswini Bajaj

Over the past decade, India’s finance talent pool has expanded rapidly. Access to education has improved, certifications are more widely pursued, and exposure to financial concepts has increased.

But the biggest concern in finance education today is the shift towards attention-driven learning. Content is designed around what attracts students rather than what builds competence. Short formats and superficial explanations that feed quick outcomes dominate the learning experience. Concepts today are often reduced to headlines such as “spot a multibagger in 15 minutes” or “quick frameworks to analyse stocks”. While engaging, such formats only create an illusion of understanding.

Structural gaps

Finance does not operate at this level of superficiality. A fund manager allocating significant capital does not make decisions in minutes. This requires in-depth business analysis, industry dynamics, macroeconomic variables, and risk factors. When education prioritises speed over substance, students begin to value



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From credentials to competence

Why finance education needs to connect to the real world

completion over comprehension. Over time, it translates into a superficial familiarity, not real capability.

At the structural level, finance education remains fragmented. Subjects such as Economics, Financial Reporting, Risk and Regulation are taught independently. But finance is an interconnected discipline. A change in interest rates, for instance, is not just a macroeconomic adjustment. It has a direct influence on banks’ profitability, credit growth, liquidity requirements, and valuation across sectors. Regulatory constraints further shape how these effects play out.

If somebody fails to connect these variables, the analysis remains incomplete. Closing this gap demands a shift in focus so

that students understand how these factors interact in real-world situations.

While every finance role does not demand the same level of expertise, each requires depth in its relevant domain. Students need a strong grounding in quantitative methods, statistics, and behavioural dynamics if they are preparing for trading roles. A career in corporate finance or banking requires a deeper understanding of macroeconomics, regulation, and financial systems.

Often, the attempt is to cover everything at a surface level. Effective programmes focus on role-specific depth first and then expand to connect with the wider financial ecosystem.

While the rise of AI ac-

celerates learning by processing information fast, it also enables shortcuts. If used incorrectly, it can weaken a learner’s instinct to understand concepts. Today, students leverage AI to complete assignments without conceptual clarity, which gradually dilutes their independent thinking. In finance, if you don’t have conceptual clarity, it becomes difficult to distinguish between error and insight. Depth of a concept cannot be outsourced to AI.

What can be done

These gaps arise from how finance training is delivered. Finance evolves continuously, so outdated curricula and static case studies quickly lose relevance. Institu-

tions must regularly update their curriculum which reflect real-world conditions.

Second, students today have reduced attention spans. Therefore, concepts need to be engaging without being diluted. This involves clear explanation, strong storytelling, and practical application. Most importantly, depth must be prioritised over completion. Covering more topics does not create better professionals; deeper understanding does. If the problem is rooted in education, the solution must begin there.

Fundamentally, the issue is less about an individual’s capability and more about how the capability is being shaped. The system, as it stands, efficiently produces individuals who are excellent within defined expectations. However, their ability to engage with the context remains limited, and their capacity for independent judgement is often underdeveloped. Addressing this gap demands a reorientation of the approach and seeing finance as an interconnected system.

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Kartikeya Bolar

Comparing the changes in research today with the shift from a manual to an automatic gear transmission is pertinent. While the trip is the same, technology has altered the effort and skill needed to reach a destination. The new “automatic transmission” that is transforming the research process is AI.

For decades, research was conducted as if it were rush hour on a highway. Each task required conscious human involvement and hard work. Journal articles needed to be located individually by the researcher, articles sorted, literature summarised, gaps identified, articles written, language edited and citations formatted. Just like changing gears and controlling the throttle in manual transmission, each step of the research process had to be closely supervised.

Researchers learnt to be patient, analytical, and rigorous since all output was a result of a sustained manual effort. The process of development, however, was cumbersome, tiring, and complicated. The



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Shifting gears

AI is changing research the way automatic transmission changed driving

amount of time a researcher spends on innovation and theory building is not as much as in repetitive academic activities.

Changing the game

Automatic transmission ushered in a new era, just like AI has started to change the game in research. Automatic transmission does not replace people driving the vehicles but merely frees them from the physical burden of driving and allows them

to focus on other aspects without constantly having to shift gears.

Similarly, AI tools assist researchers, automate repetitive tasks, and reduce day-to-day tasks. They can summarise long articles, take notes in an organised manner, outline themes, brainstorm research questions, improve language, and format citations. This leaves the researcher with more time to spend on interpretation, conceptual thinking and strategic ana-

lysis. But this shift has led to the same debate that occurred when vehicles with automatic transmission became popular. Veteran drivers felt that these cars made people too reliant on technology and led to a decrease in driving skills. In the academic world, educators worry about the potential loss of students’ critical reading and analytical thinking abilities due to excessive use of AI.

Concerns

These are legitimate concerns. Drivers who are not guided by a human brain may let their guard down, leading to unsafe driving. Likewise, when a scholar trusts the results of an AI system without examining the content, the scholarship generated is likely to be shallow and incorrect. While AI systems can produce convincing content, they sometimes make subjective statements, misquote, or generate false conclusions. AI does not have the ability to independently formulate meaningful research questions, set limits for ethical issues, and inspire genuine curiosity. It is devoid of humanity, context, emotional intelligence and philosophy.

Therefore, the researcher remains responsible for determining which questions are important, what evidence is reliable, and what conclusions are morally and scientifically acceptable.

The transformation does not so much involve elimination of the researcher as it does an alternative thinking about his/her competence. The future researcher is like today’s driver in many ways. Just as drivers of automatic-transmission vehicles are assessed for awareness, decision making, safety, adaptability and responsible handling of complex situations, researchers in an AI world should be assessed for originality, ethical behaviour, critical thinking and synthesis of knowledge.

The final responsibility in a vehicle – whether manual or automatic transmission – is that of the driver. Similarly, the end result of research should be based on the researcher’s intellectual depth, integrity and creativity.

The writer is Professor, Information Systems and Analytics at TA Pai Management Institute, Manipal Academy of Higher Education